

held; Mandeep and Sukhjeet were barely visible. Shilanand Lakra and Aditya Lalage were the saving grace, though not by much.

Goalkeeping: In a battle between two equally ordinary players, Pawan came off slightly better by the barest of margins. But neither he nor Suraj Karkera is a match for the rest of the world, and it is the one department that India desperately needs to decide on, as soon as possible. The search for a successor to P.R. Sreejesh is still on.

The team clearly is not at optimum fitness, or even good

Silver lining: Hardik Singh tried to lift India in midfield, one of the few to show urgency in a winless home run.

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enough to last two back-to-back matches at 100 per cent intensity. Whether it is the body refusing to obey the mind or a general lack of preparation and planning, the basics were abysmal: back-passes into empty space, or worse, to the opposition; faltering traps and mispasses galore; beginners' errors in defence; inability to earn PCs even inside crowded circles; and leaving wide open spaces for rivals to move in and out of easily, while not creating any for themselves. What made it worse were the team's determined, positive starts in every game, only to lose steam and their senses as the matches wore on. Clearly, the mind space needs equal attention.

"Four losses are four losses, but if you look behind those results, we've just come out of HIL, we've got a bigger squad, we're trying to put together

performances that we can be proud of. I think the effort was there... I know we're not where we want to be, but I know what they (the seniors) can do. There are lots of things that I know we can do a lot better when we spend more time together," Fulton reiterated.

He agreed there was pressure on the players but insisted it was good. "There's selection, so that's what we're doing. So yeah, there's pressure all the time. And it's

healthy, because it needs to drive a certain level of competition; otherwise, what do we have? We're doing the experiments now; after that, we don't have time. There's a selection camp in March which will give us the squad to play with Malaysia, New Zealand, and Australia. Get that World Cup squad, Asian Games squad together, start to get our combinations ready for Pro League and go."

India finally halted its five-match slide in Hobart, clawing back to 2-2

HEAD COACH CRAIG FULTON HAS URGED PATIENCE, BUT INDIA HAS LITTLE TIME BEFORE THE WORLD CUP AND ASIAN GAMES TO FIX ISSUES AND SETTLE COMBINATIONS

in regulation before losing 5-4 in a tense shootout to Australia.

The point did little to transform the standings, but it offered something Fulton has been asking for: evidence that the group can stay in contests even when execution falters.

Fulton's faith in his boys is commendable; for his and the team's sake, hopefully, they reciprocate sooner rather than later.